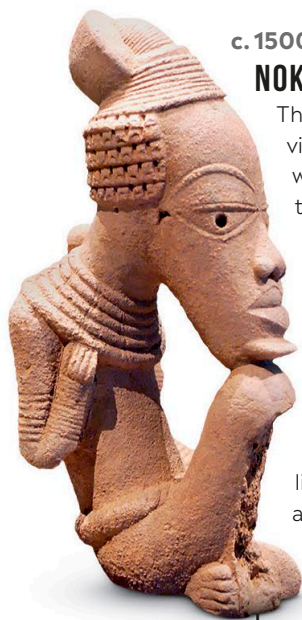




c. 1500 BCE

NOK CULTURE EMERGES

The Nok culture, named after the village of Nok where its artefacts were first discovered, began to develop in what is today Nigeria. Best known for their stylized terracotta figures, the Nok people also discovered iron-smelting at around the same time as the Iron Age was getting under way in Europe and Asia. Their civilization was very long-lived, lasting until its sudden and mysterious disappearance in about 500 CE.

◁ Nok terracotta figure



1336 BCE Pharaoh Tutankhamun and his queen Nefertiti restore the old Egyptian religion

1500 BCE

c. 1400 BCE Vedic Sanskrit-speaking peoples migrate into India from the northwest and then spread out across north India

1348 BCE Religious reforms instituted in Egypt by Pharaoh Akhenaten reject old gods in favour of sun worship

1300 BCE Urnfield culture, named after the practice of storing cremated ashes in urns, emerges in central Europe



△ Assyrian cylinder seal with its impression

c. 1400 BCE

ASSYRIANS ASSERT INDEPENDENCE

After centuries of existing as disparate subject states of successive Akkadian and Babylonian empires in Mesopotamia, the Assyrians began to emerge as a single independent power.

1500–500 BCE THE IRON AGE



Iron smelting was developed in Asia, became widespread in the Middle East in the 12th century BCE, and slowly spread around the world.

c. 1500 BCE The Hittites in Anatolia develop techniques of iron-working (as seen in the axe head, above), but closely guard the secrets to maintain their superiority over neighbouring states.



c. 1000 BCE Iron technology spreads into western Asia and Europe, reaching as far north as the Shetland Islands (above). It is also discovered by the Nok of West Africa.



c. 500 BCE Chinese metalworkers learn the processes of smelting and working iron and begin producing intricate pieces, such as this gold-inlaid belt hook (above).